

AI Usage Note - ThesisTrail

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Product: ThesisTrail

Tools used

- **ChatGPT** - assignment interpretation, ambiguity exploration, planning, critical review, and edge-case identification.
- **Cursor** - implementation assistance, refactoring, tests, accessibility/security audit prompts, and repository checks.

I did not rely on Claude, Copilot, or other coding assistants for this repository beyond what Cursor's agent workflow provided.

Where AI helped

AI helped me explore alternative interpretations of the seed question, challenge soft assumptions, scaffold Next.js modules, propose Vitest cases, review user-facing copy for overclaiming, and structure accessibility and security checklists. It accelerated drafting; it did not replace judgment.

Decisions I retained

I kept a narrow product scope; an explicit provenance model (user stated / proposed / confirmed / derived); next-open entry; a five-session inclusive hold; median event-versus-baseline as the primary comparison; a fixed OHLC snapshot; the source date-boundary correction to **2007-09-17**; a deterministic research engine; the **negative** locked result; and a hard rule that AI may assist question interpretation only-never calculations or LEARN conclusions.

Suggestions I rejected or modified

I rejected authentication/database, live market APIs, multi-agent designs, same-close execution, optimizing parameters for a positive historical story, making the core workflow provider-dependent, and excessive charts or decorative fintech UI. When AI suggested broader "productization," I narrowed back to the experiment contract.

How I verified AI-assisted work

Strict Zod boundaries on interpret and run payloads; hand-worked fixtures; an independent calculation oracle; fixed regression values for counts and primaryDelta; SHA-256 checksum verification of the bundled CSV; and manual responsive/accessibility inspection of the real ASK->LEARN path. AI-assisted code was reviewed against docs/EXPERIMENT_CONTRACT.md and rules.md before acceptance.

Most proud of

The visible trail from a vague question through confirmed assumptions to deterministic evidence-and keeping an unfavorable result, because the experiment (not the pitch) is the product.